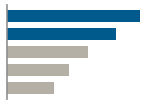
Chart chooser

Pick the chart from the question, not from habit.

1. Write the question the chart answers in one sentence.
2. Find the question type and start with its first choice.
3. Check the traps on the next page.
4. Follow the chart's page to build it.

Every chart name links to its page in this guide. **Avoid** lists the charts that look right for the question but mislead or slow the reader.



Magnitude

How big? Which is bigger, by how much?

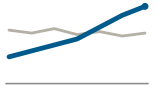
START WITH	**Sorted bar**
ALSO	Dot plot for values far from zero; paired bars
AVOID	Rainbow, 3D or cut-off bars



Part-to-whole

What is it made of? How does a total break down?

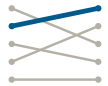
START WITH	**100% stacked bar**
ALSO	Waterfall between totals; treemap for many parts
AVOID	Pies over 5 slices



Change over time

How is it moving? When did it change?

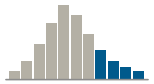
START WITH	**Line**, focus series in blue
ALSO	Stacked area; small multiples; bubble timeline
AVOID	Ten colored lines



Ranking

Who's on top? Who moved?

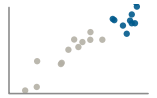
START WITH	**Sorted bar**; **slope** for change
ALSO	Dumbbell for us vs. them; heat table
AVOID	A color for every line



Distribution

How spread out? What's typical?

START WITH	**Strip plot** or **histogram**
ALSO	Box plot to compare many groups
AVOID	An average with no spread



Correlation

Do two measures move together?

START WITH	**Scatter** or bubble scatter
ALSO	Heatmap: two categories, one measure
AVOID	Dual axes



Relationships and flows

How do things connect or move?

START WITH	**Sankey**
ALSO	Parallel coordinates; Venn, 3 sets max
AVOID	A color per stage



Geo-spatial

Where? Does place matter?

START WITH	**Choropleth** for rates
ALSO	Bubble map for counts; world map; zoom-in
AVOID	Counts on a choropleth



Single number

What one figure should they remember?

START WITH	**Big number** with a comparison
ALSO	Progress bar or ring for a target
AVOID	Speedometers

CHART CHOOSER

Before you build: the common traps

The right chart type can still go wrong. If you are about to do one of these, use the fix instead.

The page numbers refer to this guide's PDF; on screen, each fix links to its page.

ABOUT TO	INSTEAD	
Cut the bar axis so small differences show	Bars from zero; a dot plot for a narrow range	p. 19
Give each bar its own color	Grey bars, the one that matters in blue	p. 19
Put two units on two axes	Two aligned panels, or index both to 100	p. 62
Draw ten lines in ten colors	All grey, one or two in blue; or small multiples	p. 35
Make a pie with eight slices	A sorted bar; donuts take five parts at most	p. 31
Stack eight segments in a bar	Five at most, the story segment blue on the baseline	p. 24
Color a waterfall green up, red down	Favorable teal, unfavorable orange; or grey with one blue	p. 27
Map raw counts by state	Map rates; show counts as bubbles	p. 80
Show a KPI as a speedometer	A big number with a comparison, or a bar to target	p. 87
Paste a 30-row table to make one point	Chart the point; keep the table for the appendix	p. 50
Put four charts on one slide	Two at most, each with its own insight headline	p. 92
Show a team of 7 people	Suppress or combine groups under 10	p. 15